seek international pressure, India also went on a diplomatic offensive, with ministers fanning out across the world.[146]

At the onset of the crisis, as Kissinger later put it, the White House's major objective had been to "maintain Pakistan's goodwill" in order "to preserve the channel to Peking."[147] In early April, Beijing's invitation to an American ping-pong team to visit China had pleasantly surprised Nixon and Kissinger. They were even more delighted when at the end of the month the Pakistani ambassador conveyed Zhou's invitation to Nixon or an emissary to visit China.[148]

Subsequently, unbeknownst to the State Department, planning got underway for Kissinger to visit China through Pakistan. Nixon instructed that nothing be done to "squeeze" West Pakistan.[149] Thus, despite congressional and media appeals, Nixon and Kissinger initially refused to cut off aid to pressure Pakistan to accommodate East Pakistani demands for autonomy.[150] However, State Department officials, having not received instructions from the White House, went ahead and embargoed military exports.[151]

Congressional and Indian criticism of Nixon's attitude increased in the summer, when reports emerged that Pakistan was still receiving arms shipments from the US that had slipped through the State-engineered embargo.[152] This made Indian officials question whether the US was an honest broker. They acknowledged the financial assistance that the US and others were providing India to cope with the growing influx of refugees, but they doubted whether the Nixon administration was making a serious effort toward getting Pakistani leader Yahya Khan to the negotiating table.[153]

The reason for the limited White House effort was that, while Gandhi's concern was the implications of the crisis in Bengal, Nixon was concerned about the effect on Beijing. The president told Kenneth B. Keating, ambassador to India, that a Pakistan collapse was "certainly" not in US interests at that time: "For reasons we can't go into … we've got to take up here for reasons that go far beyond India-Pakistan relations another position."[154] He resisted congressional calls for pressure on Yahya while Kissinger was in the midst of the July trip that would take him to Delhi, Islamabad, and (secretly) Beijing. Moreover, the White House found work-arounds to a congressional embargo on economic aid to Pakistan, took a